



1878-1953 JOSEPH STALIN

Josef Stalin ruled the Soviet Union for 30 years, first as part of a leadership team, later with dictatorial powers. His brutal rule came to overshadow his role in defeating Nazi Germany in World War II.

1955 TELEVISION REACHES A MASS AUDIENCE

Black-and-white television sets made their first appearance in the 1920s, but it was only after World War II that they became a regular feature of middle-class homes.

In 1950, only 9 per cent of US households had one, but by 1959 the figure was over 80 per cent; colour television followed in the 1960s.



△ Graetz tabletop television set, 1953

14 May 1955 The Warsaw Pact links the Communist nations of Eastern Europe in a defensive alliance

21 September 1955 Military leaders topple Juan Perón from his post as President of Argentina

1955

“The enemy has overrun us. We are blowing up everything. Vive la France.”

THE LAST FRENCH RADIO COMMUNICATION FROM DIEN BIEN PHU, 7TH MAY 1954

1954-1968 THE US CIVIL RIGHTS MOVEMENT



The fight for social justice and racial equality in the US gained huge momentum in the 1950s. Grass-roots groups fought inequality and forced changes in state and federal laws.

1955 Rosa Parks refuses to give up her seat to a white man on an Alabama bus, inspiring a boycott of the bus company.

1962 James Meredith becomes the first black student to attend the University of Mississippi, despite attempts to bar him.

1963 Martin Luther King gives his “I Have a Dream” speech; Medgar Evers, civil rights activist, is assassinated.

1964 The Civil Rights Act is signed into law, prohibiting employment discrimination. A second act follows in 1968.